

A **SIMPLE BUT STYLISH** man is a conductor on bus number 10A in erstwhile Bangalore (now Bengaluru). Elsewhere, an innocent milkman leads a contented life.

One day, the conductor's bus-driver friend urges him to join the Adyar Film Institute in Madras (now Chennai). Another day, the milkman's wealthy hotelier best friend betrays him.

The aspiring actor gets noticed by the noted Tamil film director K. Balachander, who offers him a role in his movie and rechristens him. The enraged milkman vows to become more successful than his friend.

The actor ascends from negative roles to stardom, acting in more than 170 films over the next 50 years. The milkman toils over the next 15 years to become a wealthy hotelier, while his friend descends into a downward financial spiral.

The reigning 'superstar' of the Tamil film industry makes fans go crazy well into his twilight years. The milkman wins the challenge and reconciles with his repentant friend.

84 | These are both tropes of a rags-to-riches story worthy of a commercial potboiler. But one is the real-life tale of Shivaji Rao Gaekwad who became 'Rajinikanth'. The latter is the plot of the 1992 film *Annamalai* that transformed him from a star into the aforementioned superstar.

The reel-meets-real backstory is one of the powerful drivers of 'Brand Rajini'—which offers possibilities and hope of a better tomorrow to his audience and has propelled his own stratospheric growth to the top. And his appeal doesn't seem to be waning. The actor, who will soon turn 73, has delivered one of the biggest super hits of his career in the recently released *Jailer*. It collected ₹600 crore-plus in worldwide box office collections and raked in more than ₹150 crore in profits for producer Sun Pictures. Rajini himself took home a whopping ₹110 crore pay cheque, excluding the profit share and a BMW X7 gifted to him by an elated Sun Group Founder-Chairman Kalanithi Maran.

One of India's most bankable stars, he is still one of the highest-paid leading men in all of Asia, especially in his age bracket. "His films are watched by everybody from babies to 90-year-olds. That's why his collections are high and that's why his own salary has also risen," says *Kabali* producer Kalaipuli S. Thanu, who first publicised him as 'superstar' in the posters for the Tamil film *Bairavi* (1978).

But *Jailer* is a much-needed super hit for the star, coming after a decade of lacklustre films such as *Kuselan*, *Lingaa*, *Kochadaiiyaan*, and 2021's *Annaatthe*. Though he first played his age in *Kabali* (2016), it took him another seven years to finally hit the mark as a retired cop in *Jailer*. "The film's success is a combination of his persona and good content which appeals even to the audience of today who may not have been born when he was at the peak of his powers in the mid-'90s," says trade analyst Sreedhar Pillai.

PACKING A PUNCH



At 72, Tamil actor Rajinikanth has delivered one of his biggest hits as a leading man in *Jailer*. The film grossed ₹600 crore worldwide



The actor took home a whopping ₹110 crore (estimated), making him one of the highest paid leading men in his age group in all of Asia



Industry veterans feel the hefty fee is justified because of the superstar's sway over the box office for more than 40 years now



A 'minimum guarantee' actor, his 170-odd films have rarely been loss-making ventures for producers, distributors or exhibitors

PHOTO BY JAISON G

